CHAPTER 6

OCCULTURE IS ORDINARY

Christopher Partridge

While Western esotericism has its roots in the Hellenistic world of the first few centuries of the Common Era, and while much contemporary esoteric thought can be traced back to the rediscovery of early texts during the Renaissance (and, particularly, to the modern occult revival of the nineteenth century), the late modern period since the 1960s has witnessed the emergence of a political and cultural context that has proved particularly conducive to the proliferation of broadly esoteric ideas. Indeed, no longer can such thought be considered occulted or esoteric, in the sense of being recondite and secretive. While there are, of course, occult traditions and organizations that are styled as such, concerned with the cultivation of a sense of gnostic privilege, the culture in which they are embedded is no longer hidden or unfamiliar. It is ordinary and everyday.

The well-documented shift from "religion" to "spirituality",[1] the turn to the self, the change of focus from external authority to inner experience has significantly increased the appeal and respectability of esotericism. Indeed, such has been the change in the oc/cultural climate that, not only is there widespread popular interest in magic and occultism, but students can now study for degrees in esotericism at some European universities.[2] This chapter is

1. See Woodhead & Heelas, *The Spiritual Revolution*; Heelas, *Spiritualities of Life*; Partridge, *Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 1.
2. For example, there is a "Center for History of Hermetic Philosophy and Related Currents" at the University of Amsterdam, and Exeter University has established the "Exeter Centre for the Study of Esotericism". There are also several learned societies, notably, the "European Society for the Study of Western Esotericism", the "Association for the Study of Esotericism", the "Society for the History of Alchemy and Chemistry", and "Societas Magica". There are also a number of academic journals devoted to the study of the subject: *Aries: Journal for the Study of Western Esotericism*; *Esoterica*; *Gnostika*; *Ambix*; and *Magic, Ritual and Witchcraft*.

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about this new climate. That is to say, rather than providing an analysis of, for example, particular esoteric traditions or organizations, the following discussion is primarily concerned with exploring the social and cultural conditions, the occultural context within which contemporary esotericism thrives.

OCCULTURE IN LATE MODERN SOCIETIES

The winds that ushered in this more temperate climate within which esotericism has flourished have been guided by the broad contours of modernization and related cultural influences, from Romanticism to Easternization.[3] We might, for example, consider the ways in which modern societies and political systems have witnessed a shift towards individualization, the result of which has been a turn away from deference to traditional sources of authority, and a turn towards personal experience and freedom of choice. It is also worth noting that Western modernity has been shaped by colonialism, in that not only has there arguably been significant Easternization,[4] particularly evident in Theosophical currents, but that this has included a conspicuous orientalism,[5] which has, in turn, significantly supported the turn to the self. This, again, has all provided a climate favourable to the growth of esotericism. Furthermore, late modern capitalist societies, characterized by unprecedented levels of affluence, have become sites of conspicuous consumption within which spirituality, therapy and the pursuit of wellbeing have become commodified, marketed, branded and invested with economic value.[6] Of course, for many Westerners born since 1960, this is not an odd state of affairs. Because they have been shaped by a culture of consumption, they have, as Wade Clark Roof has commented, "looked on [spirituality] in much the same way as other purchasable goods".[7] While this does not necessarily reduce esotericism and the pursuit of spirituality to the profit motive, it does link it, along with other lifestyle acquisitions, to identity and the construction of the self. Added to this, globalization and technological advance have led to rapid recent changes in people's lifestyles, the corresponding result of which has been ever more complex changes to our self-identities.[8] Indeed, in the 1970s, Ronald Inglehart persuasively argued that the affluence of post-industrial societies had created a situation in which individual values were being transformed from materialist values,

3. See Partridge, *Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 1; Woodhead & Heelas, *Religion in Modern Times*; Heelas, *Spiritualities of Life*; Colin Campbell, *The Easternization of the West*.
4. See Partridge, *Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 1, 87–118; Colin Campbell, *The Easternization of the West*.
5. See Partridge, "Lost Horizon".
6. See Einstein, *Brands of Faith*.
7. Roof, *A Generation of Seekers*, 195.
8. See Robertson, *Globalization*; Clarke, *New Religions in Global Perspective*.

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which focused on the securing of life's basic necessities, to post-materialist values, which emphasized self-expression, subjectivization, and experience.[9] However, the point is that such post-materialist values provide fertile ground for contemporary esotericism, the claimed effect of much of which is, generally speaking, personal empowerment, metamorphosis, and liberation through the acquisition of illuminated knowledge (gnosis) and, as such, the developing of one's potential as a human being in relation to the cosmos. In other words, in affluent, information-rich, self-oriented societies, in which our basic needs are catered for, we have the time to seek and the money to purchase experiences and lifestyles.

Finally, in recent years, it is difficult to ignore the findings of studies which suggest that generational repositioning has contributed to subjectivization, post-materialism, and a culture within which esotericism flourishes. For example, in their study of post-Christian spirituality, Stef Aupers and Dick Houtman argue that this is largely driven by cohort replacement, in that younger generations with stronger affinities to, and a greater penchant for, post-Christian spirituality have simply replaced an older generation for whom this was not the case.[10] This concurs with other research indicating a shift from the religious patterns of pre-baby-boomers (who came of age in the 1960s) to the largely self-oriented spirituality of Generation X (born between 1961 and 1981). Key to this shift, of course, was the rise of youth culture and the increased influence of popular culture, both of which have contributed to an independence from the values of the previous generation. Moreover, this was a generation born into an affluent society that enabled the exercise of that independence and to challenge, what appeared to be, the flawed values of the previous generation – values which had walked them into Vietnam, the Cuban Missile Crisis, Watergate, and much more. Generation Y (born between 1982 and 2000) have, as well as continuing to benefit from higher rates of education and affluence, not to mention the growth of information technologies ("the Internet is one of the most important places where Witches meet"[11]), become increasingly alienated from traditional religiosity.[12] As Peter Brierley has shown of church attendance in the UK, "undoubtedly the biggest shift age-wise in the church in recent years was the huge decline in numbers of young people in the 1990s".[13] Influenced far more by popular culture and subcultural peer

9. See Inglehart, *Culture Shift in Advanced Industrial Society*; Inglehart & Abramson, "Measuring Postmaterialism". Interestingly, from a different perspective, Frank Furedi has made a similar point concerning the new highly individualized and emotivist therapeutic culture in which the self is perceived to be diminished and vulnerable and in which "virtually every challenge or misfortune that confronts people is represented as a direct threat to their emotional well-being" (Furedi, *Therapy Culture*, 1).
10. Houtman & Aupers, "The Spiritual Turn and the Decline of Tradition".
11. Berger & Ezzy, *Teenage Witches*, 139. See also Cowan, *Cyberhenge*; Erik Davis, *Techgnosis*.
12. See Tomasi, *Alternative Religions Among European Youth*.
13. Brierley, *Pulling Out of the Nosedive*, 112.

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pressure, there has, again, been a shift away from the authoritarian aspects of religion and toward the creation of personal spiritual paths. As Helen Berger and Douglas Ezzy comment of contemporary Wicca in their study of teenage witchcraft, "the emphasis in ritual and in all self-transformation techniques is individual discovery and self-development. There is no clear list of behaviours, such as those that exist in Islam, Judaism, or Christianity, that adherents are expected to change or adopt."[14]

The evidence, therefore, would seem to suggest that Western culture is not becoming *less* religious, but rather that it is, for a variety of reasons, becoming *differently* religious. Rather than becoming secularized it is, as I have argued elsewhere, witnessing a confluence of secularization and sacralization, at the heart of which is a deceptively powerful "occulture".[15] Even if individuals are not convinced of all the claims made by particular spiritualities, philosophies or esoteric systems, there is, nevertheless, a conspicuous interest in them and a growing credulity concerning their plausibility. Indeed, there appears to be a constantly replenished reservoir of beliefs and practices associated with esotericism, Theosophy, mysticism, neopaganism, the paranormal, and a range of other ideas from the bizarre to the familiar, a reservoir that is constantly feeding and being fed by popular culture.[16] In order to adequately theorize and organize these processes, I introduced the category of occulture. Just as, arguably, occult and magical thought was once a widespread familiar feature of Western societies, in the sense that their members possessed a consciousness that genuinely participated in an enchanted world,[17] so today, particularly since the 1960s, we are witnessing the increasing ordinariness of occulture.

Occulture, as a sociological term, refers to the environment within which, and the social processes by which particular meanings relating, typically, to spiritual, esoteric, paranormal and conspiratorial ideas emerge, are disseminated, and become influential in societies and in the lives of individuals. Central to these processes is popular culture, in that it disseminates and remixes occultural ideas, thereby incubating new spores of occultural thought. For example, whether one considers the ideas articulated in television series such as *Dark Skies*, *The X-Files* and *Supernatural*, films such as *Rosemary's Baby* (1968), *The Wicker Man* (1973), *Angel Heart* (1987), *Contact* (1997), *The Sixth Sense* (1999) and *Paranormal Activity* (2007), the claims made for the phenomena captured in reality television programmes such as *Ghost Hunters* and *Most Haunted*, the conspiratorial ideas developed in books such as *The*

14. Berger & Ezzy, *Teenage Witches*, 34.
15. Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*; Partridge, "Alternative Spiritualities, New Religions, and the Reenchantment of the West".
16. Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 1, 65. See also Kripal, *Authors of the Impossible*.
17. See Frances Yates, *The Occult Philosophy in the Elizabethan Age*; Berman, *The Reenchantment of the World*.

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Stargate Conspiracy, *Holy Blood, Holy Grail* and *The Da Vinci Code*,[18] or the ideological themes and styles disseminated within popular music and acted out within their attendant subcultures,[19] popular (oc)culture provides a space within which there is an openness to the possibility of metaphysical interpretation. For the scholar of religion this is, of course, important, in that popular culture becomes a significant area of inquiry as an agent of contemporary re-enchantment.[20] However, it is no easy task mapping the flow of ideas and the creation and dissolution of synergies, whether in popular culture or elsewhere. So rapid is the flow that once mapped, occultural content quickly becomes passé.

OCCULTURE, THE OCCULT AND THE CULTIC MILIEU

In the early 1970s, the British sociologist Colin Campbell observed that cultic organizations seem to arise out of a general cultural ethos, a cultic milieu, which, he argued,

> can be regarded as the cultural underground of society. Much broader, deeper and historically based than the contemporary movement known as *the* underground, it includes all deviant belief systems and their associated practices. Unorthodox science, alien and heretical religion, deviant medicine, all comprise elements of such an underground.[21]

The cultic milieu described by Campbell included networks and seedbeds of ideas, as well as various authoritative sources and particular groups. Indeed, the cultic milieu, as understood by Campbell, was essentially "occult culture". That is to say, its centre of gravity is modern occultism, magic, and certain ideas and Easternized themes developed within 1960s countercultural movements. More recently, Jeffrey Kaplan and Heléne Lööw have revisited the theory, identifying the cultic milieu as a "zone in which proscribed and/or forbidden knowledge is the coin of the realm, a place in which ideas, theories and speculations are to be found, exchanged, modified and, eventually, adopted or rejected by adherents of countless, primarily ephemeral groups".[22] However, while Kaplan and Lööw have made creative use of Campbell's theory and highlighted its value, they have not, it seems to me, been wholly successful

18. See, for example, Partridge, "The Occultural Significance of *The Da Vinci Code*".
19. See Partridge & Christianson, *The Lure of the Dark Side*; Granholm, "'Sons of Northern Darkness'".
20. See Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*; Partridge, "Religion and Popular Culture".
21. Colin Campbell, "The Cult, the Cultic Milieu and Secularization", 122 (emphasis original).
22. Kaplan & Lööw, *The Cultic Milieu*, 3.

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in applying it to the contemporary world. Their attempt to develop the cultic milieu model is essentially Procrustean. Indeed, they themselves seem to recognize this, in that, in seeking to account for a relatively wide spectrum of ideas from nature mysticism to spiritual articulations of the gothic, and from Charles Manson to National Socialism, the theory is being stretched so far that it is beginning to show cracks:

> Adherents … are not easily diffused through the cultic milieu. Racists and neo-Nazis do not easily mix with adherents of radical environmental subculture, although the same could be said for Black Bloc anarchists and members of mainstream labor unions or adherents of the Catholic Church … This observation … points to a more complex picture than Campbell envisioned … As those of us who have studied the more esoteric reaches of the cultic milieu would attest, the milieu is vast.[23]

However, the picture is, in fact, not only rather more complex than Campbell realized, but also, I would argue, far vaster and more ubiquitous than that painted by Kaplan and Lööw. While there is, in the book they edited, a broad range of ideologies and spiritualities discussed, from the far right to the far left, they are all "oppositional by nature"[24] and, together, constitute a counterculture concerned with hidden and rejected knowledge. Indeed, although seeking to account for a vast range of ideas that converge and mutate at speed, Kaplan and Lööw still want to retain a sociological model that theorizes this enormous diversity as "a single entity".[25] This is, to say the least, problematic. Although attempting to rethink the milieu in terms of a "vast imaginary landscape inhabited by many neighbourhoods",[26] it is clearly being stretched too far. The cultic milieu theory is currently not fit for purpose.

Having said that, even if Kaplan and Lööw were able to revise Campbell's theory in order to account for the plethora of ideas they have identified, it would still fail to make sense of the processes of re-enchantment. This is why we need to think in terms of "occulture" rather than "the cultic milieu". While including the oppositional and "heterogeneous assortment" of the cultic milieu, occulture is less concerned with particular groups, systems of belief and spiritual practices – although these are important – and much more concerned with the conditions within which particular "lifeworlds"[27] are formed

23. *Ibid.*, 5.
24. *Ibid*, 3.
25. Colin Campbell, "The Cult, the Cultic Milieu and Secularization", 122.
26. Kaplan & Lööw, *The Cultic Milieu*, 6.
27. I am following Jürgen Habermas in my use of the term "lifeworld". This is important, in that it refers to the latent, taken-for-granted core values, beliefs, and understandings about who we are, how we relate to others, what the world is like, and how we fit into it. See Habermas, *Theory of Communicative Action*, vol. 2, 113–98.

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and within which plausibility structures[28] are shaped. Indeed, we will see that, from an occultural perspective, there are questions to be asked as to the extent to which we can speak of an "oppositional counterculture".[29] Hence, while there are conspicuous areas of continuity between the two theories,[30] and while I am myself indebted to the cultic milieu theory, I am suggesting that something more ubiquitous, ordinary, and less oppositional is happening. For this reason, the introduction of the term "culture" is important.

Of course, while "culture" might be interpreted in any number of ways, as a composite part of the compound "occulture", it broadly follows Raymond Williams's thesis that "culture is ordinary".[31] Hence, while the use of the term "occult" in "occulture" suggests the hidden, the exotic and the elite (which, of course, is a large part of the bookish, secretive, gnostic appeal of much Western esotericism), the addition of the term "culture" opens up a very different perspective, signifying that which is everyday. It is this latter cultural dimension that is the key to understanding contemporary occulture. This is, again, not to deny that there is, within occulture, that which is occult, esoteric, oppositional, or countercultural, but rather that occulture *per se* is largely ordinary and everyday. Again, within the idea of "occulture", the "occult" is radically modified by the word "culture". As a compound, "occulture" suggests a democratized occult, an open esotericism – "occulture is ordinary". Again, it is this very ordinariness of occulture that is not at all clear in discussions of the cultic milieu, which, we have seen, is described as being "an underground", a "zone in which proscribed and/or forbidden knowledge is the coin of the realm".[32]

Occulture describes certain shared attitudes, values, and practices that characterize society. While we might think of periods when occultural life-worlds become particularly conspicuous and influential in terms of re-enchantment, actually, occulture is never absent. It is, historically, a feature of all societies. As Kaplan and Lööw have commented of the cultic milieu, the phenomenon is hardly new:

> That there exists within every society a small but dedicated underground of true seekers of esoteric and, very often, forbidden knowledge, is well known. The Middle Ages had its heretics, magicians and alchemists whose quests were not unlike those of the seekers described by Campbell as inhabiting the cultic milieu.[33]

28. On plausibility structures, see Berger, *The Sacred Canopy*.
29. Kaplan & Lööw, *The Cultic Milieu*, 1.
30. See Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 1, 24–9.
31. Raymond Williams, "Culture is Ordinary".
32. Kaplan & Lööw, *The Cultic Milieu*, 3.
33. *Ibid.*, 1.

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Therefore, they argue, "the cultic milieu is not a product of the 1960s. Rather, it is a permanent feature of society – not just this society, but of every society for which we have historical records".[34] My point is that, while this is true, the theory of occulture requires that we consider not simply elite, underground communities with a penchant for the occult and the forbidden, but society as a whole. For example, not only did the religious values of the Church have a shaping effect on medieval society and culture, in that, as A. D. Gilbert has commented, "at all levels of social life and human need the Christian religion acquired immense and ubiquitous *utility* in the minds of medieval men", but also, at the level of popular consciousness, it actually functioned as "a vast reservoir of magical power, capable of being deployed for a variety of secular purposes".[35] This largely Christianized occulture, these synergies of Christian theology and indigenous folk beliefs, permeated all levels of medieval society. Again, evidence for such medieval Christian occulture is clearly evident in Karen Jolly's study of elf charms and popular religion in England:

> [I]nvisible powers associated with the Devil afflicted people with physical as well as spiritual ailments; hence Christian words of power made herbal medicine handed down through classical and Germanic lore efficacious against these forces … All of the remedies show the conjunction of good forces against evil forces without a necessary distinction between physical and spiritual, natural and supernatural … Any material phenomenon had a potential spiritual meaning, whether it be a demonic illness or temptation testing the resistance of a Christian or a weakness of body designed to demonstrate God's miraculous power.[36]

Keith Thomas likewise provides evidence for the widespread popular supernaturalism of the medieval period:

> The medieval Church … found itself saddled with the tradition that the working of miracles was the most efficacious means of demonstrating its monopoly of the truth. By the twelfth and thirteenth centuries the *Lives* of the Saints had assumed a stereotyped pattern. They related the miraculous achievements of holy men, and stressed how they could prophesy the future, control the weather, provide protection against fire and flood, magically transport heavy objects, and bring relief to the sick.[37]

34. *Ibid.*, 4.
35. Alan D. Gilbert, *The Making of Post-Christian Britain*, 19.
36. Jolly, *Popular Religion in Late Saxon England*, 170–71. See also Kieckhefer, *Magic in the Middle Ages*.
37. Thomas, *Religion and the Decline of Magic*, 28. See also Jones & Pennick, *History of Pagan Europe*.

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Again, as Nicholas Goodrick-Clarke has noted, D. P. Walker's landmark 1958 study, *Spiritual and Demonic Magic from Ficino to Campanella*, demonstrated that "magic was part of the mainstream in the late fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, closely connected with religion, music, mathematics, and medicine".[38] Likewise, B. J. Gibbons has shown that Western esotericism played a significant cultural role in the emergence of the modern period.[39] Indeed, whether we explore, for example, Romanticism or the cult of the Gothic, during the Enlightenment period there emerged, as Roy Porter has argued, a common trade in stock elements:

> … the mist-shrouded castle, the villain sworn to the Devil, ghosts, spectres, sorcerers and witches, a flirting with the weird, the uncanny, the bizarre, with sado-masochistic sexuality – and, underpinning all, the Burkeian obsession with dread and the infinite unknown. Supernatural elements like spectralization triggered new sexual frissons; the old demonological themes of possession, incubi and succubi were eroticized … Such disciplines as alchemy, astrology and animal magnetism, and the fringes of physiognomy and phrenology evidently enjoyed a certain vogue.[40]

While many other studies might be cited, the point is that it is hardly a new state of affairs that occulture is everyday, rather than the sole preserve of some underground cultic milieu. While continuously flowing and changing in content, breadth and intensity, it is not primarily a subterranean phenomenon, the ideas of which periodically emerge, filtered and proscribed, into the mainstream. Of course, the notion of a cultic milieu does not necessarily contradict occulture, in that occulture would help to account for the progress of the cultic milieu and the mainstreaming of its ideas. Understood in this way, the cultic milieu becomes just such an underground site of occultural coalescence, a space in which esoteric and exotic ideas can be incubated. But that is only one aspect of occulture.

In order to unpack further the notion that occulture is ordinary, it is worth quoting Williams at length, for the points he makes about *culture* can easily be applied, with a little imagination and contextualization, to *occulture*:

> The making of a society is the finding of common meanings and directions, and its growth is an active debate and amendment under the pressures of experience, contact, and discovery, writing themselves into the land. The growing society is there, yet is

38. Goodrick-Clarke, *The Western Esoteric Traditions*, 5.
39. Gibbons, *Spirituality and the Occult.*
40. Roy Porter, "Witchcraft and Magic in Enlightenment, Romantic and Liberal Thought", 249–50.

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> also remade in every individual mind. The making of a mind is, first, the slow learning of shapes, purposes, and meanings, so that work, observation and communication are possible. Then, second, but equal in importance, is the testing of these in experience, the making of new observations, comparisons and meanings. A culture has two aspects: the known meanings and directions, which its members are trained to; the new observations and meanings, which are offered and tested. These are the ordinary processes of human societies and human minds, and we see through them the nature of a culture; that it is always both traditional and creative; that it is both the most ordinary common meanings and the finest individual meanings. We use the word culture in these two senses: to mean a whole way of life – the common meanings; to mean the arts and learning – the special processes of discovery and creative effort. Some writers reserve the word for one or other of these senses; I insist on both, and on the significance of their conjunction. The questions I ask about culture are questions about our general and common purposes, yet also questions about deep personal meanings. Culture is ordinary, in every society and in every mind.[41]

Occulture is likewise used to mean *both* a whole way of life *and* the special processes of discovery and creative effort. Like Williams, I insist on both and on the significance of their conjunction. The questions I ask about occulture are questions about our general and common purposes, yet also questions about deep personal meanings. Occulturally, special processes of discovery and creative effort might include the ideas, practices and movements identified by Campbell, Kaplan and Lööw as belonging to the cultic milieu. However, while occulture *per se* includes these, it is also "a whole way of life – the common meanings".

We have seen that, in contemporary civil societies in the post-industrial West, there has been a decline of Christian hegemony, a distaste for deference to traditional authorities, such as the Church, and a turn within to the subjective life. Since the 1960s this has been supported by growing affluence, increased leisure time, the emergence and expansion of youth culture, and the triumph of both democracy and capitalism. Moreover, if the making of a society is, as Williams claims, "the finding of common meanings and directions, and its growth is an active debate and amendment under the pressures of experience, contact, and discovery", then it is also difficult to ignore the roles of media and popular culture. That is to say, not only is popular culture increasingly important for the establishment of common meanings and

41. Raymond Williams, "Culture is Ordinary", 6.

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directions, but, in so doing, it has significantly contributed to the growth and significance of contemporary occulture. From the relatively mundane to the bizarrely esoteric, from approaches to health and wellbeing to conspiracies relating world domination and apocalypse, popular culture disseminates occultural content, creates synergies and encourages new spores of occultural thought to emerge. These "new observations and meanings" are then incorporated into lifeworlds simply as presuppositions or as elements within particular systems of belief. To paraphrase Williams again, these are the ordinary processes of human societies and human minds, and we see through them the nature of occulture, both the most ordinary common meanings and the finest individual meanings.

Particularly interesting are the successes of conspicuously occultural books and films such as Dan Brown's *The Da Vinci Code* and *Angels and Demons*, and films such as Roman Polanski's *The Ninth Gate*.[42] *The Da Vinci Code*, for example, won "best book" in the 2005 British Book Awards;[43] it has sold more than 30 million copies in 40 languages, and Penguin Books have even produced a guide to what I would describe as the occultural context of the novel in its Rough Guides series.[44] Indeed, as Stig Hjarvard has shown, *The Da Vinci Code*, as mediatized spirituality, not only reflects, but stimulates alternative religious interest. In a Danish survey, "more than half of the respondents report an increased interest in religious issues" after reading *The Da Vinci Code* and *Angels and Demons*.[45] As to the book's occultural content, not only is, for example, Wicca explicitly mentioned, but key neopagan themes, such as Goddess Worship, are prominent, as are discussions of popular and subculturally trendy symbols, such as the pentacle, practices such as the Tarot, and romanticized rituals such as the *hieros gamos*.[46] This contemporary everyday interest in popular occultism, reflected in *The Da Vinci Code*'s enormous success, is, again, not simply reserved for fiction, but is also evident in the fact that the percentage of esoteric books published since 1930 has more than doubled: in 1930 occult books constituted 7 per cent of religious books published. This gradually rose to 17 per cent in 1990, dipped to 11 per cent in 1995 and rose again to 15 per cent in 2000.[47] Again, Elizabeth Puttick has recently observed that there has been

> an explosion of holistic ideas and practices into the mainstream … Mind-body-spirit publishing has expanded from a specialist niche to the fastest growing non-fiction genre in a multinational,

42. See Partridge, "The Occultural Significance of *The Da Vinci Code*".
43. BBC, "*Da Vinci Code* Wins Top Book Award".
44. Haag & Haag, *Rough Guide to The Da Vinci Code*.
45. Hjarvard, "The Mediatization of Religion", 22.
46. Dan Brown, *Da Vinci Code*, 42, 43, 59–62, 129, 172, 409–10.
47. Brierley, "Religion", 666–7.

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> multimedia industry. This growth contrasts with traditional religious publishing, which is in decline. In the process, the most successful spiritual authors have become both gurus and global brands.[48]

While this shift towards an increasing occultural hegemony is relatively well documented, from both emic and etic perspectives,[49] the point here is, again, simply that occulture is ordinary.

ESOTERRORISM AND THE GENESIS OF OCCULTURE

Having discussed the theory of occulture and its relationship to the cultic milieu hypothesis, I want to return to the beginning, as it were, and briefly explore the context within which the term "occulture" arose, because, to my mind, there are few better examples of contemporary esotericism, the significance of occulture, and the power of popular culture.

Going back over a decade now, my use of the term "occulture" can be traced back to attempts to make sense of what I understood to be an ambient supernaturalism, a spiritual environment, a culture of the occult broadly conceived. At the same time, I became aware of the term "occulture" within a particular esoteric subculture oriented around industrial music and performance art. The neologism, I discovered, was probably coined by the esotericist, musician, artist and self-styled "cultural engineer" Genesis P-Orridge (Neil Andrew Megson, 1950–), whose work with the performance art group COUM Transmissions, the bands Throbbing Gristle and Psychic TV, and the spoken word project Thee Majesty developed a particular brand of transgressive, experimental, sonic and visual art. A confluence of esotericism, pornographic eroticism, violence, death, degradation, confrontation of taboo subjects and noise, his work is rarely less than confrontational. As Paul Hegarty comments of Throbbing Gristle's work, it offered "a thoroughgoing critique or even attack on conventional, modern, Christian, artistic, moral, capitalist thought and living", much of which could be understood in terms of "transgression and perversion".[50] While much of this transgression can perhaps be understood in terms of a juvenile delight gained from extreme behaviour and the offence caused by challenging taboos,[51] one also needs to understand that, certainly

48. Puttick, "Rise of Mind–Body–Spirit Publishing", 129.
49. For an interesting emic insight into contemporary occultism and youth culture, see Louv, *Generation Hex*.
50. Hegarty, *Noise/Music*, 107.
51. They will have been pleased, no doubt, when, in 1976, the Conservative MP Nicholas Fairbairn declared in the *Daily Mail*, "these people are the wreckers of civilisation" (Ford, *The Wreckers of Civilisation*, 0.12).

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in the case of P-Orridge, there was, as Don Watson argues, "a deeply rooted desire to expose and challenge the hidden mechanisms of social control".[52] It is this latter underlying motivation, influenced, we will see, very much by William S. Burroughs, that opens up some interesting analysis.

During the late 1970s P-Orridge became interested in "how a small number of fanatical individuals could have a disproportionate impact on culture"[53] – a process that became key to the sociological understanding of occulture that I was beginning to construct: micro-ideas with macro-effects. Occultural ideas articulated and developed in films, in literature, in music or on the Internet are able to have, through synergies and networks, a disproportionate influence on large numbers of people and, consequently, on institutions and societies.[54] From a sociological perspective, because occulture is ordinary, taken for granted, embedded in the everyday, its viral potential is enormous. This is a significant point, which is not lost on P-Orridge, whose interest in the influence and dissemination of esotericism is long-standing. Indeed, although it is not fully articulated in his work, it would appear that, for P-Orridge, the disproportionate influence of the esoteric ideas of a minority could have "esoterrorist" potential, if engineered carefully. Likewise, he insisted that music is "a platform for propaganda",[55] in that an individual musician or a band is able to disseminate selective information which will, not only significantly emotively influence the thinking of a particular group of people, but, by means of that affective manipulation, also subvert mainstream thinking and challenge established authorities.[56] When such activities are coupled with the energies available in magick, however these might be understood, it becomes esoterrorism. Hence, for P-Orridge, music is a particularly powerful weapon in the arsenal of the esoterrorist, for not only is it propaganda, but, he insists, "music is magick", and, as such, key to the creation of "occult culture":

> We live in limbo and thirst for freedom … Vested interests of every kind want us lazy and atrophied … Man's fall from grace is his fall from inner security. His defeat is his surrender to conditioned boundaries imposed by the strict regime of acceptability instead of the natural honesty of his individual instinct that recognises all things to be in a state of flux … We are trained to not even *want* to

52. Watson, "Beyond Evil", 30.
53. Ford, *The Wreckers of Civilisation*, 10.29. See also Vale, *RE/Search 4/5*, 62–77; P-Orridge, *Painful but Fabulous*.
54. Of particular interest is *In the Shadow of the Sun*, an occult film by Derek Jarman for which Throbbing Gristle produced a particularly menacing soundtrack.
55. Vale, *RE/Search 4/5*, 87 (see also 64–5).
56. Here, we might again mention the influence of Burroughs, who warned of the "Control Machine", by which he referred to the forces of conformity that would destroy the unique qualities of the individual.

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> think. Decondition the condition. Conditioning is control. Control is stability. Stability is safety for those with a vested interest in control. Let's go out of control. What breaks this cycle is a psychic jolt. Music is magick, a religious phenomena that short circuits control through human response. The moment we forget ourselves and end the limbo-dance we enter a world of struggle, joy and clarity. A tragic, but magickal world where it is possible to accept mortality and thereby deny death. Experience without dogma, anguish without shame or sham. A morality of anti-cult. Occult culture. Its rituals collective, yet private, performed in public, but invisible … The rites of youth. Our alchemical human heritage, encased like a cadaver in a black suit.[57]

This, of course, is a relatively idiosyncratic and convoluted understanding of magick and the occult. Having said that, it is intended to be a practical, protest esotericism for a disillusioned, unemployed "blank generation".[58] Rather than

> the magick of the Golden Dawn, designed for the stately Victorian manor … it was magick designed for the blank-eyed, TV-flattened, prematurely abyss-dwelling youth of the late Twentieth Century – like the punk kids in Derek Jarman's *Jubilee*, who have never ventured out of the council flats they were born in. Rather than high ceremony, drawing-room intrigue and exalted initiatory ritual, the focus more often than not became simple survival, and defense of individual vision from a malevolently dehumanizing culture that the Victorians and Modernists, even in their most racist and reactionary moments, could never have foreseen.[59]

Similarly, Thee Temple ov Psychick Youth (TOPY), in *Thee Grey Book*, states that it

> requires an active individual, dedicated towards thee establishment ov a functional system ov magick and a modern pagan philosophy without recourse to mystification, gods or demons; but recognising thee implicit powers ov thee human brain (neuromancy) linked with guiltless sexuality focused through Will Structure (Sigils). Magick empowers thee individual to embrace and realise their

57. Vale, *RE/Search 4/5*, 87.
58. *Blank Generation* is the title of the 1977 debut album from Richard Hell and the Voidoids. The title song reflects the despair and nihilism of the generation (see McNeil & McCain, *Please Kill Me*, 282–283). It is this despair and nihilism that lies at the heart of P-Orridge's analysis of society in the 1970s and 1980s.
59. Louv, in P-Orridge, *Thee Psychick Bible*, 18.

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> dreams and maximise their natural potential. It is for those with thee courage to touch themselves. It integrates all levels ov thought in thee first steps towards final negation ov control and fear.[60]

While clearly idiosyncratic, this functional, anti-mystical "system ov magick" indicates the breadth of interpretation of esotericism in the contemporary world. However, to understand this particular interpretation more fully, something needs to be said about the occulture of Genesis P-Orridge, about the various occultural streams that met in his life and work.

A friend of Burroughs (whom he had known since 1971), P-Orridge had, for several years, requested an introduction to Brion Gysin, the principal architect of the cut-up method, developed in 1959 and used to great effect by Burroughs. Eventually, Burroughs wrote him a letter of introduction and he met Gysin in Paris in the late 1970s, probably 1978,[61] and quickly established a close master–disciple relationship.[62] While P-Orridge was enormously influenced by Gysin, it was the cut-up method, as discussed in *The Third Mind* (a book-length collage manifesto on the method and its uses), that became central to his thought.[63] Put simply, cut-up involves cutting a text into pieces, which are then rearranged into a new text. "Whatever you do in your head", insisted Gysin, "bears the prerecorded pattern of your head. Cut through that pattern and all patterns if you want something new … Cut through the word lines to hear a new voice off the page."[64] This method of progressing beyond current patterns of thought and belief was, for P-Orridge, revolutionary. Gysin, he argued,

> understood more than anyone else at that point in culture that, just as we can take apart particles until there's a mystery, so we can do the same with culture, with words, language and image. *Everything can be sliced and diced and reassembled, with no limit to the possible combinations*.[65]

There could hardly be a better summary of occultural processes than the sentence italicized above.

60. TOPY, *Thee Grey Book*.
61. See Vale, *RE/Search 4/5*, 71.
62. See P-Orridge, *Esoterrorist*, 34–7.
63. The cut-up method was also used by other artists, notably David Bowie and Patti Smith. "'I use Burroughs' cut up technique', Bowie explained in the BBC documentary, *Cracked Actor*. The camera panned in to show Bowie tearing sheets of lyrics down the middle and moving the edges against each other to find new lines created in the process" (Sandford, *Bowie*, 120).
64. Burroughs & Gysin, *The Third Mind*, 44.
65. P-Orridge, "Eyes Wide Shut" (emphasis added).

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> If one didn't look at the very nature of how we build and describe our world, [Gysin] thought, we get into very dangerous places. Once you believe things are permanent, you're trapped in a world without doors. Gysin constructed a room with infinite doors for us to walk through. What amazed me about Gysin's work was how it could be applied to behaviour: there were techniques to free oneself through the equivalent of cutting up and reassembling words. If we confound and break up the proposed unfolding the world impresses upon us, we can give ourselves the space to consider what we want to be as a species … He would take words, break them down into hieroglyphics, then turn the paper and do it again and again until the magical square was filled with words. Gysin worked with the idea of painting as magic, to change the perception of people and to reprogramme the human nervous system … I made an agreement with Gysin before his death that I would try to champion and vindicate his work and legacy.[66]

It is difficult to imagine anyone championing his work and legacy more enthusiastically than P-Orridge. Indeed, not only did he use the cut-up method to produce new ideas, but he applied it, quite literally, to his own body in an attempt to recreate himself. He and his late partner, Jacqueline Breyer ("Lady Jaye"), following their marriage in 1993, embarked on what he termed the "Pandrogeny Project",[67] which, informed by the cut-up technique, embraced the aesthetics of body modification as the first step towards becoming a single "pandrogynous" being. Indeed, it is important to understand that, speaking in terms of a "genderless state", for P-Orridge, who now has breast implants and looks feminine, the surgery was not motivated by transsexual concerns. That is to say, he was not struggling to be female while trapped in a male body. The surgery was not even, primarily, about the construction of a post-human, post-gendered self, such as Marilyn Manson sought to explore on *Mechanical Animals* (1998).[68] Rather, this was far more of an esoteric project, in that it was an expression of his belief that the self is pure consciousness trapped in flesh and controlled by DNA. Humans are, he believes, at an early stage in their psychic evolution towards fleshless consciousness; the Pandrogeny Project is a step towards that evolutionary goal; a step away from the "control" of the DNA. He and Lady Jaye, therefore, sought to become one, in the sense

66. *Ibid.*
67. He was able to do this when, in 1998, he was awarded $1.5 million when he sued the producer Rick Rubin, following serious injuries, including nearly losing his left arm, when escaping a fire at Rubin's Los Angeles home.
68. For a good discussion of the post-human in relation to Marilyn Manson, see Toffoletti, *Cyborgs and Barbie Dolls*, 81–105.

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of becoming a "third being", Breyer P-Orridge.[69] That is to say, they referred to themselves *together*, in the singular, as Breyer P-Orridge. The Pandrogyny Project, therefore, was an empirical reflection of that singularity. However, as with much of P-Orridge's thought, it is typically occultural, in that pandrogyny is a synergy of ideas, the principal thesis drawing on a common stock of esoteric and transpersonal theories of consciousness and "Mind".[70] In other words, in a typically occultural manner, P-Orridge, wittingly or unwittingly, remixes a range of ideas with theories learned from Gysin and Burroughs, as well as his own long-standing interest in body modification.

For the esoterrorist, cut-up and the cultivation of occult culture are central to the subversion of social control, just as pandrogyny is an act of resistance to the control of the DNA. All forms of control must be disrupted and subverted. Using cut-up as an occult technique, a form of magick, he argued that a small group of esoterrorists could "have a disproportionate impact on culture",[71] disrupt social programming and consensus solipsism.

> Control. Control needs Time (like a junkie needs junk). Time appears linear. Cut-ups make time arbitrary, non-linear. They reveal, locate and negate Control. Control hides in social structures like Politics, Religion, Education, Mass Media. Control exists like a virus for its own sake. Cut-ups loosen rational order, break preconceptions and expected response. They retrain our perception and acceptance of what we are told is thee nature of reality. They confound and short-circuit Control. All Control ultimately relies upon manipulation of behaviour. In culture thee Cut-up is still a modification of, or alternate, language. It can reveal, describe and measure Control … Magick as a method is a Cut-up Process that goes further than description. It is infused with emotion, intuition, instinct and impulse, and includes emotions and feelings … Control Disintegrates. Magick integrates. Thee idea is to apply thee cut-up principle of behaviour. Thee method is a contemporary, non-mystical interpretation of "Magick." Thee aim is reclamation of self-determination, conscious and unconscious, to the Individual. Thee result is to neutralise and challenge thee essence of social control.[72]

69. "Third being" is a reference to the "third mind", created by cut-up, as discussed in Burroughs & Gysin, *The Third Mind*.
70. See, for example, Capra, *The Turning Point*, 410; Castaneda, *Tales of Power*, 100; Ferguson, *The Aquarian Conspiracy*, 73–5; Hanegraaff, *New Age Religion and Western Culture*, 245–55; Wilber, "The Atman Project".
71. Ford, *Wreckers of Civilisation*, 10.29. See also Vale, *RE/Search 4/5*, 62–77; P-Orridge, *Painful but Fabulous*.
72. P-Orridge, *Esoterrorist*, 18.

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It's worth noting that the spelling and grammar are important. Whereas the spelling of "magick" is simply taken from Aleister Crowley's spelling convention (originally designed to distinguish his theories of magic from other interpretations he considered superstitious or misguided), the other odd spellings and grammatical constructions are intended to challenge thought and ways of reading; our angle of vision is bent during the process of reading.

Concerning cut-up, this is in many ways an essentially occultural process. Indeed, it can be seen as a form of remix, as utilized in contemporary electronic music. With roots in Jamaican reggae culture, which was itself embedded in a particular occulture, remixes are often radical deconstructions of recordings.[73] The point is that cut-up or remix is central to occulture. It is not simply that particular ideas and signifiers are disseminated within an occultural environment, but rather that in the process they are cut-up, remixed, deconstructed and reconstructed. New synergies are formed, which are then, in a dialectic process, cut-up and remixed, the results of which then attach to other ideas and signifiers and so on. P-Orridge, therefore, did not simply coin the term, but he is himself an excellent example of the subsequent sociological theory. Central to P-Orridge's esoterrorist use of magick was his band Psychic TV and the related esoteric organization TOPY, founded with members from Current 93 (notably David Tibet)[74] and also, significantly, The Process Church of the Final Judgment,[75] the latter having had a formative influence on the development of his occult thought.[76] This is, again, a helpful illustration of the social processes involved. That is to say, if one considers the numerous small occultural organizations that coalesced as concrete social forms, such as those within the vampire community (e.g. the House of Kheperu and the Order of the Vampyre, the latter being a part of the Temple of Set)[77] or the UFO subculture (e.g. the Aetherius Society, Unarius, and the Raelian Movement)[78] or the numerous other occulturally informed subcultures, often there is a confluence of esoteric ideas, popular culture, and traditional supernaturalism. In other words, as with TOPY, common interests and convictions lead to the formation of concrete communities or organizations, whether virtually or in the flesh.[79]

73. See Partridge, *Dub in Babylon*; Partridge, "King Tubby Meets the Upsetter".
74. See Keenan, "Childhood's End". On Tibet and Current 93, see Fava, "When Rome Falls, Falls the World"; Moliné, "Road to Salvation".
75. On The Process Church of the Final Judgment, see Bainbridge, *Satan's Power*; Wyllie, *Love, Sex, Fear, Death*.
76. See P-Orridge, "The Process is the Product".
77. Keyworth, "Occultism and the Contemporary Vampire Subculture"; Keyworth, "The Socio-Religious Beliefs and Nature of the Contemporary Vampire Subculture"; Laycock, *Vampires Today*; Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 2, 230–38.
78. See Partridge, *UFO Religions*; Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 2, 165–206; Lewis, *Encyclopedic Sourcebook of UFO Religions*.
79. See Cowan, *Cyberhenge*; Partridge, *The Re-enchantment of the West*, vol. 2, 135–64.

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The idea of a "psychic television" is, again, significant. Although highly critical of television as a tool of mind control and mass indoctrination, it might also, as indicated above, be used by an esoterrorist as a form of magick to combat "Control" – "a modern alchemical weapon":

> [Psychic TV] are attempting to knit together thee fine lines ov shamanic initiation and voodoo invokation allegorically coded into western X-tian myth. TV itself becoums thee ceremony, thee language ov thee tribe. It becoums apparent that, cloaked in spurious messianic trivia, are ancient tantric rituals involving small death, limbo and resurrection that have now been literalised and usurped by a base language system named religion. Just as religion cloaks ancient knowledge and techniques, so Television cloaks its power to invoke thee lowest coumon denominator ov revelation … We intend to reinstate thee ability ov TV to empower and entrance thee viewer. To remove thee window and passibity, and re-enter thee world ov dreams beyond. We believe TV is a Modern alchemical weapon that can have a positive and cumulative effect upon Intuition.[80]

Understanding TOPY to be the natural successor to the early Ordo Templi Orientis (OTO), particularly under Crowley's leadership, it was established to be "a secret society created as an access point into the world of magick".[81] As Jason Louv comments in P-Orridge's *Thee Psychick Bible*:

> Neither the OTO nor TOPY were teaching orders, existing instead to foster socialization around occult ideas – halfway points for those interested in the hidden undercurrents of reality, training wheels that, when eventually discarded, would lead the individual either towards more abstruse orders of robed ritualists or, preferably, onto their own two feet and their own personal apotheosis.[82]

Concerning "occulture" *per se*, while it is not widely used in P-Orridge's writings and never fully theorized, it is important, particularly to TOPY. As Carl Abrahamsson writes in his Foreword to *Thee Psychick Bible*:

> Probably no word does better justice to the TOPY phenomenon than "Occulture." Meshing "Occult" with "Culture," there's also

80. P-Orridge, *Esoterrorist*, 18–19.
81. Louv, in P-Orridge, *Thee Psychick Bible*, 25.
82. *Ibid.*, 25.

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> a prefixed trace of "Occident" if you will. The defined concept as such was integrated in the inter-TOPY-"lingo" in the late 80s, and then grew to become a readily accepted general term for anything cultural yet decidedly occult/spiritual. As a more or less unnamed concept, Occulture had already been active in TOPY since day one. The field of research was never ever occultism *per se* or culture *per se*, but always consisted of interchangeability where eventually the clear-cut borders were gently erased. Books, pamphlets, newsletters, film and video screenings, record and cassette releases and other manifestations could certainly contain more or less blatant esoteric form or content, but it was in no way a prerequisite. The literal meaning of "occult" (as in "hidden") was given a wider perspective than the merely "magical" one.[83]

This, then, is the original context within which the term "occulture" emerged. Although there is much about P-Orridge's work with which one might take issue, such as its articulation of oppression, suffering and abuse, occasionally defended with what appears to be a veneer of unreflective or uncaring faux morality,[84] for several reasons "occulture" has proved to be a pregnant and useful term, as we have seen. Moreover, key aspects of occult culture, as understood by P-Orridge and TOPY, are useful in understanding occulture *per se*, as well as being themselves good examples of the novel ways in which esotericism is evolving in late modernity.

CONCLUDING COMMENTS

The aim of this chapter has been to develop further the theory of occulture that I posited some years ago. In order to articulate the important distinction between *occulture* and *occult culture*, this has been done with reference to Campbell's theory of the cultic milieu, the esoteric ideas of P-Orridge and TOPY, and Williams's theory of culture as ordinary. Occulture is not occult culture, in the sense that it is not a milieu of the esoteric and the hidden (although it certainly includes that which is esoteric and hidden); nor is it a site of the exotic and the forbidden (although it certainly includes the exotic and the forbidden). Rather, like culture – which, of course, it is – it is ordinary and everyday. As such, occulture, as culture, is an explanans for Western re-enchantment rather than jargon for occult culture. Indeed, it is the reason why occult culture *per se* often seems, at some level, plausible and attractive to so many people.

83. Abrahamson, in P-Orridge, *Thee Psychick Bible*, 11.
84. Stubbs, "Clearing the Wreckage"; Reynolds, *Rip It Up*, 224–44.

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Not only is there good evidence for occulture, but there is evidence that it is both generational to some extent and that popular culture is key to its efficacy. Indeed, although there are obviously exceptions and confounding variables, occulture's *current* persuasive power has a generational specificity. Again, this is perhaps saying little more than occulture moves with the times; occulture is ordinary; occulture is in accord with the *zeitgeist*. However, because occulture is ordinary, as we have seen with P-Orridge and TOPY, largely by means of popular culture and new media, individuals and small groups are able to have a disproportionate impact on the *zeitgeist*. Again, because occulture is ordinary, and because, therefore, occult culture has a certain cogency and plausibility, subversive ripples caused by minority esoteric ideas can travel a long way in society. This, of course, makes esoterrorism and theories of occultural propaganda a particularly rich area for future research.

Finally, we have seen that P-Orridge, who coined the term "occulture", is himself an interesting occultural case study. His use of the cut-up method, his founding of TOPY as an occultural offshoot of the esoteric outfit Psychic TV (through which he sought to disseminate politically subversive and occult ideas), his occultural eclecticism, his related understanding of popular music as propaganda and his esoterrorist agenda, all suggest avenues of thought that are helpful to the construction of a more developed theory of occulture.

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